

COMMUNICATION AND SPORT

COMM 118 · SANTA CLARA UNIVERSITY · FALL 2026

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Communication Department

Vari Hall 206

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OFFICE HOURS

Tuesdays 9:30 to 11:30 am, and

[by appointment](#)

CLASS MEETINGS

MWF 9:15 to 10:20 am

Vari 133

REQUIRED TEXTBOOK

Billings, A. C., Butterworth, M. L., & Turman, P. D. (2018).

Communication and sport: Surveying the field (3rd ed).

Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE.

You can also get the 2nd or 4th edition if you find it for a better price.

READINGS

On the class site,

classes.andrewishak.com/comm118

Communication is a critical component of watching and playing sports, and at the same time, sport is a lens through which we view different aspects of our cultures and interactions. This course examines sport as a component of our society, investigating:

- How sport affects the way we interact with others
- Issues of identity such as race, gender, and power
- The connection between spectator sports and media
- Communication's role in sports participation, including topics such as leadership, motivation, cohesion, and teamwork.

At the completion of this course, you will have a better understanding of selected communication principles and you will have discovered new ways to talk about sport.

ASSIGNMENTS

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WEEK	TOPIC	ASSIGNMENT
1	The Purpose of Sports	Intro post, Friday. Weekly Challenge 1: Aussie rules football
2	Value & Interest	
3	OJ. Athletes as celebrities. NIL, endorsement and who gets covered	Weekly Challenge 2
4	Legacy media, social media, storytelling. Streaming and the NFL on Netflix	Sit-Down 1 memo
5	Youth sports: cost and access	Sit-Down 1
6	Identity, informal play, and who plays what. Coaching and communication	Weekly Challenge 3: Former coach interview
7	Small groups and team interaction. Team culture	Sit-Down 2 memo
8		Sit-Down 2
9	Power: protest, organizations, money	Weekly Challenge 4: Leadership Guide, Friday. Field Guide topic, Friday
10	Wrap-up: media, participation, power. Field Guide work	
Finals	Field Guide peer review. Presentations	The Field Guide, Friday, December 11
		In-Class: Weekly Game, This or That, Around the Horn, Rotating Fishbowl, ongoing

Weekly Challenges 1 to 3 and the Sit-Down memos are due Sundays. Sit-Downs are in class, Wednesday and Friday.

Thanksgiving week is off.

You can find dates and more information at classes.andrewishak.com/comm118.

Department Learning Outcomes

The course objectives meet the following Department Learning Outcomes:

LO 1 Explain and apply communication theories and concepts.

LO 3 Analyze communication structures that maintain power and privilege and engage in practices that support diversity, equity, and inclusion.

LO 4 Analyze the ethical dimensions of communication and form judgments and practices based on evidence and values.

LO 6 Create effective and ethical oral, visual, and written communication based on awareness of diverse perspectives, contexts, and social identities.

LO 7 Design communication that fosters a more just, humane, or sustainable world.

Course objectives and assessment

COURSE OBJECTIVE	LOS	ASSESSED BY
Students will be able to explain how the advent of sports media has contributed to sports as product, spectacle, and culture.	1	Weekly Game, Sit-Down 1
Students will be able to evaluate communication theories and concepts through the lenses of professional and recreational sports.	1	Weekly Game, Rotating Fishbowl, Sit-Downs
Students will be able to analyze the impact of sports on local and global communities.	3, 7	Weekly Challenges, The Field Guide
Students will be able to find and analyze research about sports and identity.	3, 4	Sit-Down 2, The Field Guide
Students will be able to identify multiple strategies for improving communication, culture, and leadership in team sports.	6, 7	Weekly Challenge 3: Former coach interview, Weekly Challenge 4: Leadership Guide
Students will develop their own ethical approaches to consumption and/or participation in sports.	4	This or That, Sit-Downs, The Field Guide

Accommodations

If you have a documented disability for which accommodations may be required in this class, please contact Disabilities Resources, Benson 216 (www.scu.edu/disabilities) as soon as possible to discuss your needs and register for accommodations with the University. If you have already arranged accommodations through Disabilities Resources, please initiate a conversation with me about your accommodations during my office hours within the first two weeks of class.

Students who are pregnant and parenting may also be eligible for accommodations. Accommodations will only be provided after I have verification of your accommodations as approved by Disabilities Resources, and with sufficient lead time for me to arrange testing or other accommodations. For more information you may contact Disabilities Resources at 408-554-4109.

Late Work

Over many years of teaching, I have gone through a number of different policies regarding late work. What I've found is that the best policy is to be consistent, clear, and simple. This might seem strict to you, but again, this is what I've found to work the best.

If an assignment is not turned in at the deadline, the student will receive a 0 for that assignment. This includes turning in the wrong assignment, a mostly-incomplete assignment, or an assignment that doesn't meet basic requirements.

Then, the regrade policy applies. You can submit your work for up to half credit, within 48 hours after grades are released.

Regrading

If you would like to earn a higher grade, you may re-submit your assignment within 48 hours of receiving your grade. You can earn up to half of the previously unearned points.

Some assignments will not have improvement opportunities, including those submitted during Finals Week, and presentations. Please keep that in mind as we make our way towards the end of the quarter.

Plagiarism

Plagiarism and cheating in any form is unacceptable in this course, as it is in any course at SCU. There are no excuses. If you plagiarize or are found to be academically dishonest in any way, you will receive a grade of zero on that assignment. For incidents that I consider to be exceptional, you will receive a failing grade for the course. We'll talk about what counts as plagiarism, but if you're unsure in the meantime, come talk to me, or see scu.edu/academic-integrity.

AI

We'll have a conversation about AI in class. Otherwise, my expectation is that we will use AI to assist us when I call it appropriate.

Use of Classroom Recordings

Some class meetings may be recorded by the instructor and made available on the class site. As is stated in the Student Conduct Code: "...Dissemination or sharing of any classroom recording without the permission of the instructor would be considered 'misuse' and, therefore, prohibited. Violations of these policies may result in disciplinary action by the University. At the instructor's discretion, violations may also have an adverse effect on the student's grade."

Discrimination, Harassment and Sexual Misconduct (Title IX)

SCU faculty are committed to helping create a safe and open learning environment for all students. If you (or someone you know) have experienced any form of discrimination, harassment or sexual misconduct, including sexual assault, dating or domestic violence, or stalking, know that help and support are available, I encourage you seek support and report incidents to the Director of Equal Opportunity and Title IX Coordinator, Belinda Guthrie, at 408-554-3043, bguthrie@scu.edu. For more information about reporting options and resources at Santa Clara University and in the community, please visit scu.edu/title-ix. If you wish to speak with a confidential resource, please visit scu.edu/title-ix/resources/student.

Copyright Statement

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Technology Support

For Zoom assistance, contact Media Services at mediaservices@scu.edu or 408-554-4520. You can also get support from the Zoom Help Center website.

For SCU network and computing support, contact the SCU Technology Help Desk at techdesk@scu.edu or 408-554-5700. They can provide support for MySCU Portal, Duo, eCampus, hardware and software issues, and more.